Course Reflection Assignment

Assignment Focus: Reflect on Your Learning and Growth
Type: Formative
Course: USA Soccer D License

Personal Growth

What is one thing about yourself that helped you learn in this course?

I try to check my ego at the door, recognizing that every person in the room has something they can teach me. I'm also curious and constantly looking to simply improve, because the question is not who knows the most, it's can I get better?

How did your team or coaching situation affect what you learned?

This is the first time I have jumped into the high school age pool in 20 years, so I see it all from a vastly different perspective than my first go round, leaving a lot to learn.

Coaching Experience

What is something new you tried as a coach because of this course?

Mic'd up myself when talking to the boys. I usually do not like people hearing what I say inside the huddle, but back to the personal growth thing: while it's scary, it's also a great way to get feedback and improve.

Did this course change how you think about your coaching job or team? How?

It reinforced the structure and preparation needed to be effective, especially with this age.

Coaching Philosophy

Did you learn a new idea about coaching that you want to use?

Many of the high-level fundamentals I have been exposed to multiple times, but below that there were several new ideas presented by both Bryan and peers in the class, which I tried to remember and absorb. They are not so much concepts (e.g. game-realistic environment, play/practice/play, etc.) but ideas around execution and, again, planning and preparation.

Is there a value or belief you want to add to your coaching approach?

Player-first approach. I think I have done that in the past, but this course reinforces and reminds me how important that is. New ideas and perspective in the development vs competition calculus. There was also a class a few weeks ago where we talked about celebrating kids' little victories, and since then that idea has really embedded itself in my brain, and I have tried to integrate it more and more into my style of coaching.

Motivation for Coaching

Did anything in this course make you more excited or interested in coaching? What?

Listening to all the other coaches reminds me of where I have been and how lucky I am to be at the high school level, reaping the rewards of the years of hard work of these coaches.

Did you learn something new about why coaching or youth soccer is important?

Increasingly I believe that while everyone can jump into the game at any time and find joy in it, the holistic USA Soccer approach applied to youth, starting at our youngest ages, is exactly the kind of infrastructure we need to start turning USA Soccer into a legit world contender. It's the kind of thing that was totally absent when I grew up, so being a part of the grassroots system shows how important a mature, structured approach to the technical, tactical, psychological and physical aspects of the game really is.

Player-Centered Coaching

What is one new thing you learned about focusing on your players?

Meeting players where they are, providing opportunities to compete and push themselves, keeping them engaged, and maximizing touches and decisions in every activity. These might not be new things I learned, but they were reinforced and brought back to the forefront for me.

What is one way you'll help or listen to your players more after this course?

A balance of leading by example, guiding using questions, and inviting player input into the game or training session.

Course Goals and Next Steps

Did you reach your main goal for this course? Why or why not?

Yeah, I think so. If the goal is to help build up or train coaches to create effective, player-centered learning environments, then yeah, this certainly helped.

What is the most important thing you learned that you'll use as a coach?

The boys are always watching. Your behavior, language, posture, and attitude matter more than you know.

What is one thing you want to try next as a coach?

1. Season theme (e.g. this year is "direction") that we can build on and refer back to all season long.
2. Starting something called "the Monday huddle," where the captains and one selected player meet to talk about the previous week and goals for the upcoming week. We did something like that for football (called "Quarterback Club") when I was young, and it always pushed me to try harder to get a spot at the table. And when I did, it was so cool to see how the coaches talked and planned, and then when they asked for my opinion, it really made an impression.

Future Learning Goals and Application

How will you use what you learned in your next practice or game?

Very practically speaking, I will use the drill I made up for the first homework assignment tomorrow night as the practice part of a play/practice/play format, which has increasingly become my standard format (though I would call it warmup/play/practice/play).

What are you curious to learn more about after this course?

I want more strategic and tactical education. I know how I see the game and I try to push myself to keep learning, but it's hard when all I have is EPL games and YouTube videos. A place to talk strategy and tactical execution would be awesome.

What is one thing you want to get better at as a coach?

Observing and analyzing the game. I can certainly get caught watching (enjoying) the game too frequently. As a player I was so immersed I could see the game before it happened. I could analyze so quickly; it was so natural. As a coach, I struggle with that. Perhaps it's because I'm at a different vantage point, far removed from actually moving on the pitch. Whatever it is, I still feel like I need to be better.

Course Experience

How did your educator or fellow coaches help you learn?

The conversations were my favorite part. I often gained clarity through dialog, either because they saw something I didn't or perhaps because I wasn't tracking the point being made. Another thing that was fun and helpful was Bryan breaking down video and talking through various options and what he saw.

The other thing was feedback. A couple of moments I most clearly remember were feedback that didn't align with my opinions. In both cases I believe I learned or saw something I didn't before.

What is one way you helped others in the course?

Same thing. Dialog and feedback.

Coaching Moments and Lessons

Share a favorite or special coaching moment you had during the course

Putting in a JV player who earned the privilege to play varsity. I pulled him off the bench halfway through the second half and told him he had 7 minutes to make something happen. Three minutes later, he almost scored. It was glorious. That was just yesterday. I sent him a text today telling him how awesome I thought that was, and his response (grateful for that opportunity and those 7 minutes) was pure gold.